

JAK Inhibitors: The Next Wave of RA Treatment

Tofacitinib, baricitinib and upadacitinib explained for patients.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-19 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Tofacitinib, baricitinib and upadacitinib explained for patients.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]](#)[\(/conditions/rheumatoid-arthritis\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Randomised trials have shown that JAK inhibitors (Janus kinase inhibitors) can be very effective in reducing the symptoms of rheumatoid arthritis, such as pain, swelling, and stiffness. These medications work by blocking specific pathways in the immune system that contribute to inflammation. For many people, this can lead to significant improvements in their quality of life.

Systematic reviews, which combine the results of multiple studies, confirm these benefits. They also highlight that while these treatments can be powerful, they come with potential side effects that need careful consideration. Clinical guidelines from professional bodies recommend JAK inhibitors for people whose arthritis hasn't responded well to other types of medication, often after trying conventional disease-modifying anti-rheumatic drugs (DMARDs) or biologic therapies.

Overall, the picture from the evidence is that JAK inhibitors are an important addition to the treatment options for rheumatoid arthritis, offering a new pathway to manage the condition for those who need it. The focus is always on balancing the benefits of symptom control with managing any potential risks, tailored to each individual's health.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Stopping medication abruptly:** This can lead to your symptoms returning or worsening. Always discuss changes with your doctor first. * **Ignoring side effects:** Even mild side effects should be mentioned to your care team. They can help adjust your treatment or offer solutions. * **Comparing your progress to others:** Everyone's journey with rheumatoid arthritis is unique. Focus on your own improvements and challenges. * **Not asking questions:** If something isn't clear, ask your doctor or nurse. Understanding your treatment helps you manage it better. * **Neglecting regular exercise:** Staying active, even gently, helps maintain joint flexibility and muscle strength. Find what works for you.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While managing rheumatoid arthritis is a long-term journey, there are times when you should seek prompt advice from your doctor, physiotherapist, or rheumatology team. Don't wait for your next routine appointment if you experience any of the following:

- * Sudden, severe pain or swelling in a joint.
- * New or worsening fever, especially if accompanied by chills.
- * Signs of infection, such as redness, warmth, or pus around a joint, or a general feeling of being unwell.
- * Any new, unexplained symptoms that concern you, particularly if they appear shortly after starting a new medication.
- * Rapid loss of function or inability to move a joint that was previously manageable.

Frequently Asked Questions

What are JAK inhibitors and how do they work? JAK inhibitors are a type of medication that targets specific pathways within your immune system. They block the activity of enzymes called Janus kinases, which play a key role in the inflammatory process linked to rheumatoid arthritis. By doing this, they help to reduce inflammation, pain, and joint damage.

Are JAK inhibitors suitable for everyone with rheumatoid arthritis? No, they are not suitable for everyone. They are typically considered when other treatments, like conventional DMARDs or biologic therapies, haven't worked well enough for you. Your doctor will assess your overall health, other medical conditions, and potential risks to decide if a JAK inhibitor is a safe and appropriate option for you.

What are the possible side effects of JAK inhibitors? Like all medications, JAK inhibitors can have side effects. Common ones can include infections (like colds or shingles), headaches, and digestive upset. More serious but less common side effects can include an increased risk of certain serious infections or blood clots. Your doctor will discuss these risks with you before starting treatment and monitor you closely.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about jak inhibitors: the next wave of ra treatment?

Short answer: JAK inhibitors reduce rheumatoid arthritis symptoms like pain, swelling, and stiffness by blocking specific immune system pathways that cause inflammation. They are an option if other treatments haven't worked and can significantly improve quality of life. However, they come with potential side effects, such as infections, and may not be suitable for everyone. Your doctor will assess risks and benefits.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk